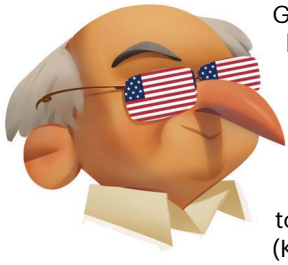
AMERICAN DREAM



Gujarat CM **Bhupendra Patel** has been marking some unusual political milestones of late. Earlier this month, he reached the US to promote the upcoming Vibrant Gujarat Investors Summit, the first sitting CM from the state to do so in over three decades (Keshubhai Patel was the last, in 1995). Washington had denied a visa in 2005 to then CM, Narendra Modi. Bhupendra also completes five years on the trot as CM next month, only the fifth person to do so in 66 years of Gujarat's history, after Congress's Hitendra Desai and Madhavsinh Solanki and BJP's Modi and Vijay Rupani.

SELF-GOAL



The official X handle of the Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) has been on a fault-finding mission of late. On I-Day, it pounced on Bihar industry minister Shreyasi Singh for mistakenly calling Mahatma Gandhi "Rashtrapati" instead of "Rashtrapita" and also posted a video of health minister Nishant Kumar saluting in the direction of the camera after unfurling the tricolour. But then, on August 17, fate returned the favour. At a party meeting to remember 'Mountain Man' Dashrath Manjhi, RJD chief **Tejashwi Yadav** accidentally referred to him as Jitan Ram Manjhi, the NDA ally and Union minister. Predictably, there was no party post to highlight his slip of the tongue.

DISSECTING A DEFEAT



After the BJP's Datia bypoll defeat in Madhya Pradesh, the blame game is on. The first round saw the district BJP unit being dissolved; now party leaders are pressing for police SP Mayur Khandelwal's transfer for not "delivering" the seat. Posted only in May, sources say Khandelwal may become a scapegoat in the **Narottam Mishra-CM Mohan Yadav** tussle. Yet it may also save him. During the campaign, the ex-home minister had warned that he had a long memory for who was friend and foe, after the SP acted against his supporters for blocking a highway. Transferring Khandelwal now would vindicate Mishra's ire, the last thing the CM would want.

Kaushik Deka* with *Prasad Nichenametla, Avaneesh Mishra, Jumana Shah, Amitabh Srivastava* and *Rahul Noronha

HEALTH WATCH

SYNTHETIC PANEER WORRIES ANYTHING BUT DAIRY

By **Sonali Acharjee**

India's analogue or synthetic paneer controversy is increasingly becoming a question not just of food labelling, but of what consumers are actually putting on their plates. Unlike paneer, which is made by coagulating milk, analogue paneer replaces some or all dairy components with cheaper non-dairy ingredients.

Reports of fake paneer have been coming from various parts of India. In Surat, Gujarat, police busted a unit in March 2026 that was allegedly producing about 400 kg of analogue paneer a day and had been operating for two years; in Maharashtra, the Food and Drug Administration department says 35.4 per cent of the paneer samples it tested between April 2025 and March 2026 failed standards. The substitutes typically include vegetable fats or oils, starch and emulsifiers, sometimes combined with milk solids. Palm-based fats are commonly used because they are inexpensive and help manufacturers recreate the richness, firmness and mouth-feel of dairy fat. Palm oil is often processed into harder fats for use in manufactured foods. These fats can be relatively high in saturated fatty acids.

Starch, meanwhile, adds bulk and helps give analogue paneer its familiar firm, sliceable texture. The nutritional consequences depend on the formulation. Conventional paneer provides substantial amounts of complete milk protein and calcium; an analogue version may contain less of both while providing more refined starch and added fat.

At home, starch is among the easier adulterants to detect: paneer can be boiled in water, cooled and tested with a few drops of iodine; a blue or blue-black colour indicates starch. Of course, further testing is needed to confirm the 'fake paneer'.



HARDIK CHHABRA